Psalm 13

Abandonment and Adoration

"How long, LORD? Will you forget me forever?
How long will you hide your face from me?"
(Psalm 13:1 NIV)

Surveying the Garden

This psalm pursues a deep quest. It grapples with our sense of God's absence, which could raise a question of God's abandonment of us or our inattentiveness to him.

This psalm's questioning is not just about knowing God, but about finding a restored sense of God's presence. That is the quest for intimacy in the Psalms. Silence can easily be misread, but he is there.

These passages resonate with people like Job, the author of Ecclesiastes, and the countless pilgrims, like you, who want to know God as present and living. The shared experience of humanity wrestles with a sense of absence, especially in the midst of pain and doubt.

With the void comes distress, anxiety, depression, loneliness, and sometimes deep despair or agony. Today, the garden echoes with emptiness and prayers of urgency. The deep yearning for intimacy permeates every fiber of our being. This hunger cuts to the core of our existence as persons.

The whole of our being is at stake in this psalm. We are facing who we are and will become in life's challenging pilgrimage. Our body will face the threat of aging and eventually death. Our emotions are often spent in sorrow or weariness. Our thinking is often interrupted, consumed by questions that entomb us.

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Who are you in "moments of missing" like a "minus one," in a romantic setting, feeling all alone? You cannot be the same "you" when a beloved other is absent. You want to go through life as a "plus one." Even those who are single need family and friends to maintain emotional health. You need others in order to fully be you, especially as your anchor in the storm. Hope remains but diminishes as you are worn down.

Abandonment issues often arise from unfulfilled expectations. These may occur due to prolonged absences or becoming aware that the care of another is lacking. What is missing is feeling valued. This may manifest as feeling forgotten, perhaps devalued, or missing the assurance that you matter. It sucks the life out of you. Being valued and belonging give us the gift of being found desirable. Our life has meaning. That is what God's love establishes for you.

This void echoes with your absence, a longing for reunion.

This psalm reveals that even in life's most confusing moments, we find God's unwavering faithfulness. He knows you and says, "They are singing our song," and you know you have found the One who resonates with your soul.

Seated at his table, with bread and wine of remembering, you recall this One as a faithful friend. He is not lost in the past; he has always been there for you. He is present as he remembers you to himself. Presence comes in the remembering of feeling at ease and at home.

Upon returning to his table and eating with him, you recognize that his absence reminded you that you desire him, and he is fond of you returning regularly. Absence was anticipation.

The sun comes out. You feel like celebrating. You now experience the happiness that overcomes feelings of neglect caused by your misplaced focus.

Jesus's presence brings an attitude adjustment. He has been patient, waiting for your return. He dances over the void and invites you to join him.

Jesus says, "I have you. I always do. Breathe in My readiness to stand by you, walk with you, and carry you through. Then sing out that song of gladness. Let our song expand in you with all the passion and joy that can be exhaled from you. Let My Spirit renew you, wash your pain, and bring you into the pleasure of Our company. You are not alone."

Into the Garden with God

The psalmist acknowledges but is also concerned by our profound longing for connection. This longing is not a bad thing. It echoes a spoken love, shared in the past, still yearning for reunion.

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Yearning for the face of the one you love reveals your heart's orientation. When they are gone, your face loses its glow, and the light in your eyes dims.

This psalm illuminates our core commitment, allowing us to feel our pulse rise as we seek to find this kind of love that hungers for face-to-face connection.

This desire to see the face of God is portrayed in the Aaronic blessing:

> **The LORD bless you, and keep you;**
> **25 the LORD cause His face to shine on you, and be gracious to you;**
> **26 the LORD lift up His face to you, and give you peace.**
> (Numbers 6:24–26 NASB)

This is a prayer with a goal of a transforming gaze. When the Lord turns toward us, we bask in the warmth of his shining face. This personal connection, initiated by Jesus and reflected in our faces, continues to have an impact until his grace finally reaches our hearts.

In 1 Corinthians, being face-to-face with God is anticipated as our ultimate goal. For now, God is mediated in a reflected way, like seeing someone standing behind you glimpsed in a mirror. In the mirror, you may catch an echoed image of them; you have to turn around to look at them face-to-face.

This reflection of God points us to reality. It awakens a desire for deep togetherness. Paul says,

> **For now we see only a reflection as in a mirror;**
> **then we shall see face to face. Now I know in part;**
> **then I shall know fully, even as I am fully known.**
> (1 Corinthians 13:12 NIV)

Knowing and being known is the final bliss.

Today, we are like-minded with Paul, intent on the time when face-to-face encounters achieve the fullness of love and joy. We live with the current reality and acknowledge the emerging sense of distance.

Jesus sees you on the other side of the maze of life. He promises, "I am here. Talk to me. Eat my Meal. Be with those who love Me. My life is the shared life; share it with Me."

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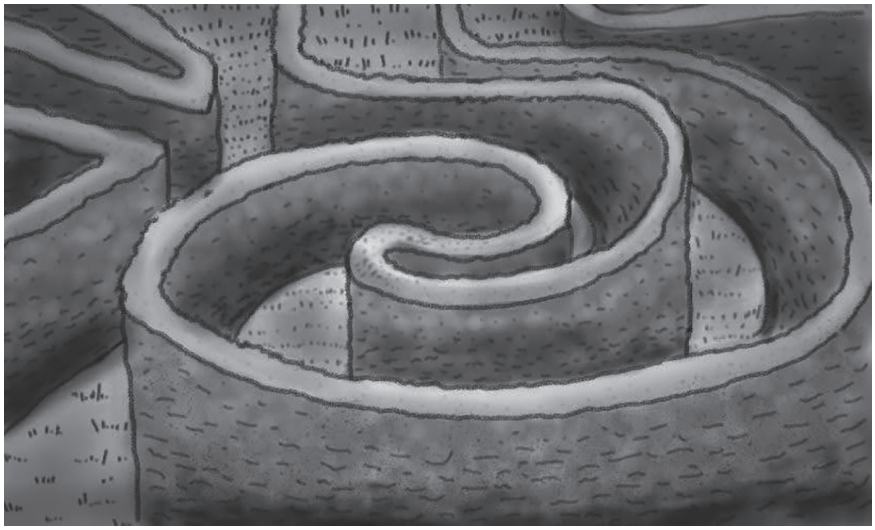
Visions of Paradise



A maze is full of anticipation and waiting to reach the far end. How long one will be in the maze depends on how well one knows the way, or desires to get to someone waiting at the other end. It is full of mystery, but the anxiety of the journey is worth it for the reconnection at the finish.

Along the Garden Path

"How much longer?" is a typical back-seat complaint. A child's anxiety reveals that they have not yet learned to enjoy the journey. But it is an honest question that needs an answer.

Telling a story about the joy of seeing the person at the destination can refocus on hope, creating a picture of being met with a smile, a hug, and a good laugh.

This path we are on today is not easy. It is a long pilgrimage. It begins with being perplexed.

The psalmist is stuck between memories of connection and delight with his God, as well as the impending, threatening possibility of death. Enemies lurk near the psalmist; they will be glad when he is gone; their jeers are in his ears.

This is a grief observed, life out of control. Ahead is the slog of daily endurance.

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Four times the words echo out on the "Welcome Mat" of this psalm: "How long?" There is a tense feeling that, if this is a game of hide-and-seek, it has been too long! This is an intensely personal path. Fear floods one's thoughts. Is this rejection? Is this absence or simply neglect? Whatever it is, it tears at the heart. *How long*?

His thoughts, a tangled maze, present a bewildering series of considerations. Reflecting on these feelings is an isolating experience. Plans and possibilities that were a cause for joy have now become a racket inside our heads.

During the storm, you are covered with a blanket of grief. You wish you could just hide, to be left alone. It is made worse by a further hailstorm of agitators that batter and ridicule you.

Finally, your anxiety begs for intervention. You want to be heard. You need answers. You want to be seen.

The darkness of death dissolves as you awaken to heaven's breaking light. Now, there is a glow in your eye, not coming from within; it reflects his light. The Spirit has found you and brought you to the welcoming presence of God. You feel courageous.

Then, an awareness of God's unfailing love comes to you. The rain and sunshine of emotions all come at once. The cleansing rays of hope create a rainbow, a reminder of God's covenant love. Suddenly, you are sustained by trust. Your heart enlarges. The storm clouds are swept away.

Then comes the song. The melody is simple and sweet, sung from long ago. It is the melody of divine hope.

You realize that the feeling of unrequited love was simply a result of your forgetfulness. God's love comes to us first and is unconditional. That love never fails. What remains is our response: to be free, made whole by the One who loved us all along. Belonging is the final resolve.

This is the spring that we drink from; this is the source of our exuberance. The song inside breaks into expressions of simple desire, to bask in the generous goodness of this One who is our resounding joy.

Much of our life is anticipation. But stay on the path and feel the sacred touch of unreserved grace and healing at the end. Take the step, knowing it is an adventure together.

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Indwelling the Garden

[1] How long, LORD? Will you forget
me forever?
How long will you hide Your
face from me?

Never-ending wait,
You seem so late,
As I linger in this silent time.
When will Your face
Make present your grace?
On Your lap I long to climb.

[2] How long am I to feel anxious in my
soul,
With grief in my heart all the day?
How long will my enemy be exalted
over me?

My musing mind
Confusion finds
I need Your calming voice.
I feel within
A saddening spin
As foes infringe my choice.

[3] Consider and answer me, O LORD my
God;
Enlighten my eyes, or I will sleep the
sleep of death,

Respond and see,
Oh, LORD who frees,
Illuminate my sight.
My heart grows dim
I fade within;
Death is my steady plight.

[4] And my enemy will say, "I have
overcome him,"
And my adversaries will rejoice when
I am shaken.

I feel put down,
In tears I drown,
Enduring hurtful acts.
Adversity hails,
My spirit fails;
Enemies laugh at my lack.

[5] But I have trusted in Your
faithfulness;
My heart shall rejoice in Your
salvation.

I bathe in Your love,
Poured from above,
Your compassion never fails.
My ecstasy swells,
Your joy indwells,
Now safe from all that ails.

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[6] I will sing to the LORD,
Because He has looked after me.

My voice shall dance,
My feet shall prance,
Abundance shall fill my life.
Your daily gifts
Shall heal all rifts;
Your provisions heal all strife.

Taking Reflections with You

You have probably known dark places of disappointment. Today you have an appointment to meet with the One who is always available—the appointment is *for us* to take time, not because he is hard to get in to see!

- Do any *words* in this psalm resonate with your sense of God not being available for you? What *words awaken* in you the enduring faithfulness of God?
- How did this psalm awaken your desire to cry out, "How long?" In what way did the movement that began with desperation and ends in exaltation help you to see the nature of God in your life in a new way?
- How did this psalm center you regarding what is missing and what your ultimate joy is in fulfilling *who you are*? What is your identity in relation to suffering? Do you feel a victim in any way?
- What does this psalm reveal about *your relationship with God*? To whom or what do you give your whole heart and being? What does it feel like to awaken to One who affirms his never-ending love?
- When his love breaks through in this psalm, what do you hear *spoken to you*?
- What *words of response* would you mirror back to God from this psalm?

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Final Embrace

Sitting in a cloud of unknowing, we feel an internal push in our waiting with big questions, wanting big answers. Questions are the keys to life that take us beyond the clouds to see what is known there. Life is best if we let discovery be our guide. Read and see what you discover in each word as a window to your emotions.

Impatient.
Forgotten.
Waiting.
Debating.
Where are You?
This lonely view.
Feeling tossed.
Lost.
If only.
You were here too.
Without You.
Distress.
Within me.
Sorrow.
Above me.
Silence.
Around me.
Intimidation.
Wrestling.
Perplexing.
Grieved.
Bereaved.
Needing You beside.
Intervene.
Look at me!
Listen to me. . . .
Shine on me.
Ignite in me.
The fire of You.
Renew.
Infuse.
Love profuse.
Heartened news.
Your promise true.
I sense the warmth.
The joy.
The trust.
Your evermust.
To stand.
Sustain.
Be the same.
I know.
I know.
I know.
You are there.
Wellspring.
Life to bring.
Joy.
Release.
Peace.
Songs to free.
In me.
Adoration.

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